

Conducting Effective Problem Solving Teams

Matthew Burns, Ph.D.
University of Minnesota

Overview of Multi-Tiered Academic Interventions

Tier I: Universal screening and progress monitoring: All students,

Tier II: Standardized interventions delivered in an efficient manner (small groups) : 15% to 20% of students at any time

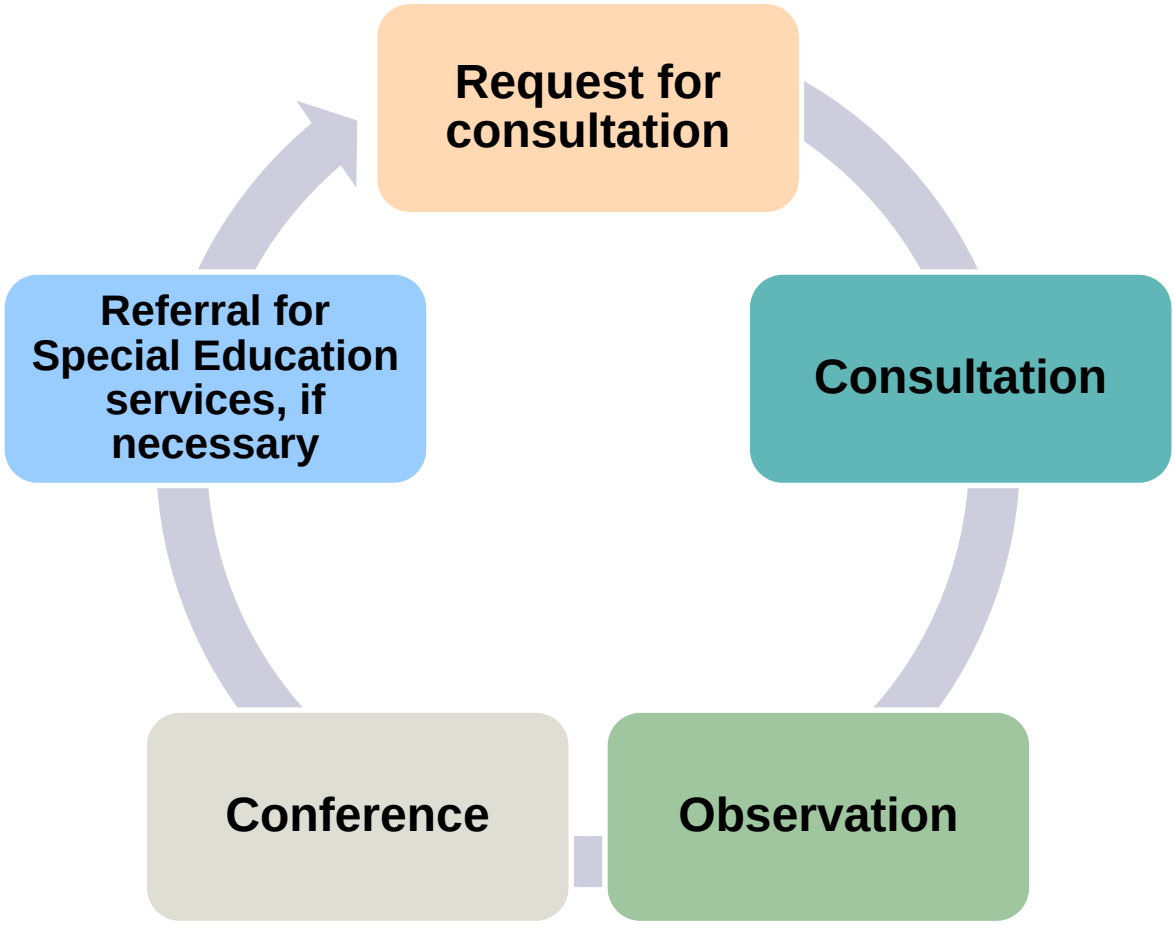
Tier III: Individualized interventions developed through in-depth problem analysis: 5% of students at any time

Pre-referral Intervention Teams

- What do they do?

- A collaborative problem-solving approach to increase teacher effectiveness and support students who were difficult to teach

Pre-referral Intervention Process



(Burns & Symington, 2002).

Research on Problem Solving Teams: Meta-Analysis

Pre-referral intervention teams (PIT)

- *d* = 1.10
- **Variables**
  - Student = 1.15
  - Systemic = .90
- **Design**
  - University-based = 1.32
  - Field-based = .54

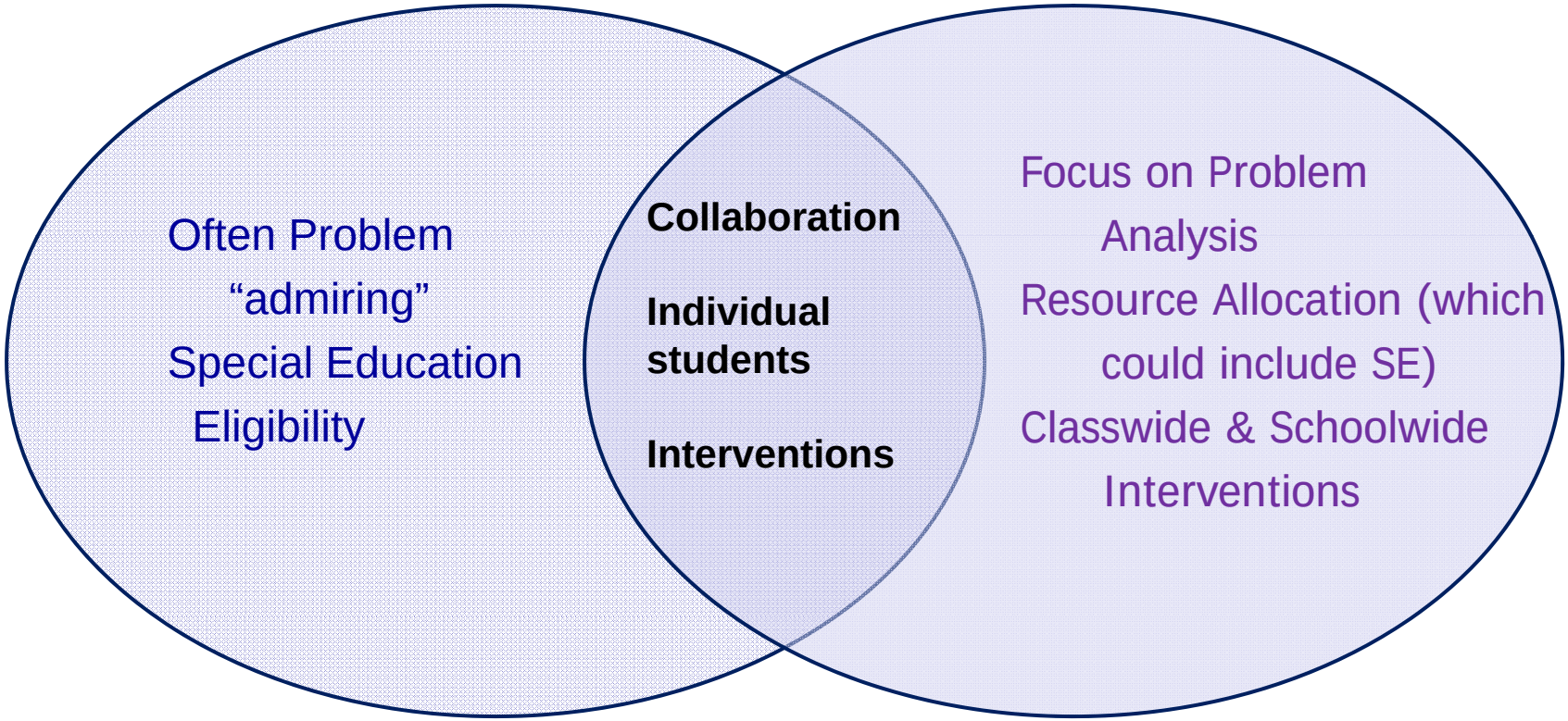
Burns & Symington, 2002

Problem-Solving Team (PST)

- *d* = 1.02
- **Variables**
  - Student = .72
  - Systemic = 1.28
- **Design**
  - University-based = .86
  - Field-based = 1.02

Burns, Appleton, & Stehouwer, 2005

Problem-solving Team vs. Pre-referral Intervention Team



How to turn a pre-referral intervention team

(PIT) into a problem solving team (PST)?

Collaboration

- Shift of responsibility to sharing responsibility

- Membership
  - Referring teacher
  - Another general education teacher
  - Special education teacher
  - School psychologist
  - Others as needed (another teacher, Title I teacher, SLP, counselor, social worker, nurse, etc.)
  - Principal?

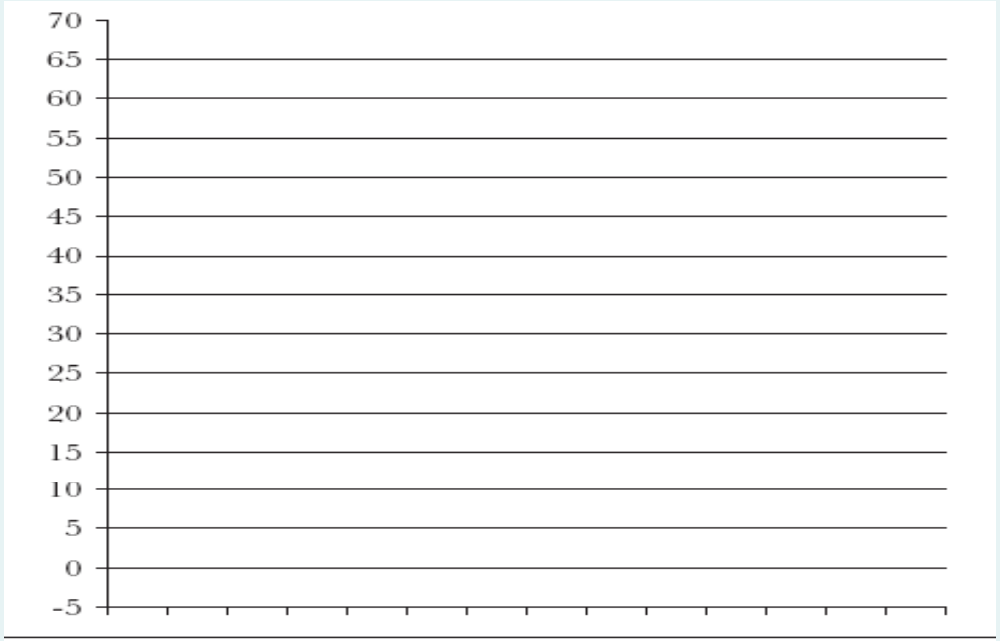
Team Roles

- Number of members
  - 5 – 8 (Rosenfield, 1996)
  - 7 or fewer (Zins, 1988)
- Systems Manager
  - Organizes meeting & monitors status
- Problem-solving Facilitator
- Consultant

Consultation

- Within 2 to 5 days of referral
  - Behaviorally define problem
  - Prioritize
  - Observe kid/baseline data
- Conduct meeting within 2 weeks
  - 10 to 15 minutes
- Meet within 2 weeks of conference
  - discuss the teacher's understanding
  - assess implementation integrity
  - problem solve previously unforeseen difficulties with the intervention

Student Name:	**Grade:**	**Gender: Female Male**
Parent(s):	Referring teachers:	Date of Referral:
Teacher Concern:		
Date of Initial Consultation:	Consultant:	
Behaviorally Defined Problem:		
Relevant Information from the Cumulative File:		
Relevant Information Obtained from the Student:		
Relevant Information Obtained from the Parent(s):		
Baseline Data:		
Interventions Attempted Before Problem-Solving Team Conference:		

Date of Problem-Solving Team Conference:		
First:_____	Second:_____	Third:_____
Second Intervention: Person responsible and timeline:		
Date of first follow-up:		
Third Intervention: Person responsible and timeline:		
Date of second follow-up::		
Relevant Information Obtained from the Parent(s):		
Data: 		

Problem Identification

Grade Level Team

- GLT makes referral!
- Level is below expectations
- Slope of growth in Tier II low

Problem Analysis

- Structured!

	R Review	I Interview	O Observe	T Test
I Instruction	Review Instruction	Interview Instruction	Observe Instruction	Test Instruction
C Curriculum	Review Curriculum	Interview Curriculum	Observe Curriculum	Test Curriculum
E Environment	Review Environment	Interview Environment	Observe Environment	Test Environment
L Learner	Review Learner	Interview Learner	Observe Learner	Test Learner

Note. Adapted from Heartland Area Educational Agency II (2002).

Interventions (reason for failure)

1. They don't want to do it
2. Haven't spent enough time on it
3. They've not had enough help with it
4. They have not had to do it that way
5. It is too hard

Daly & Martens, 1997

Implementation Integrity

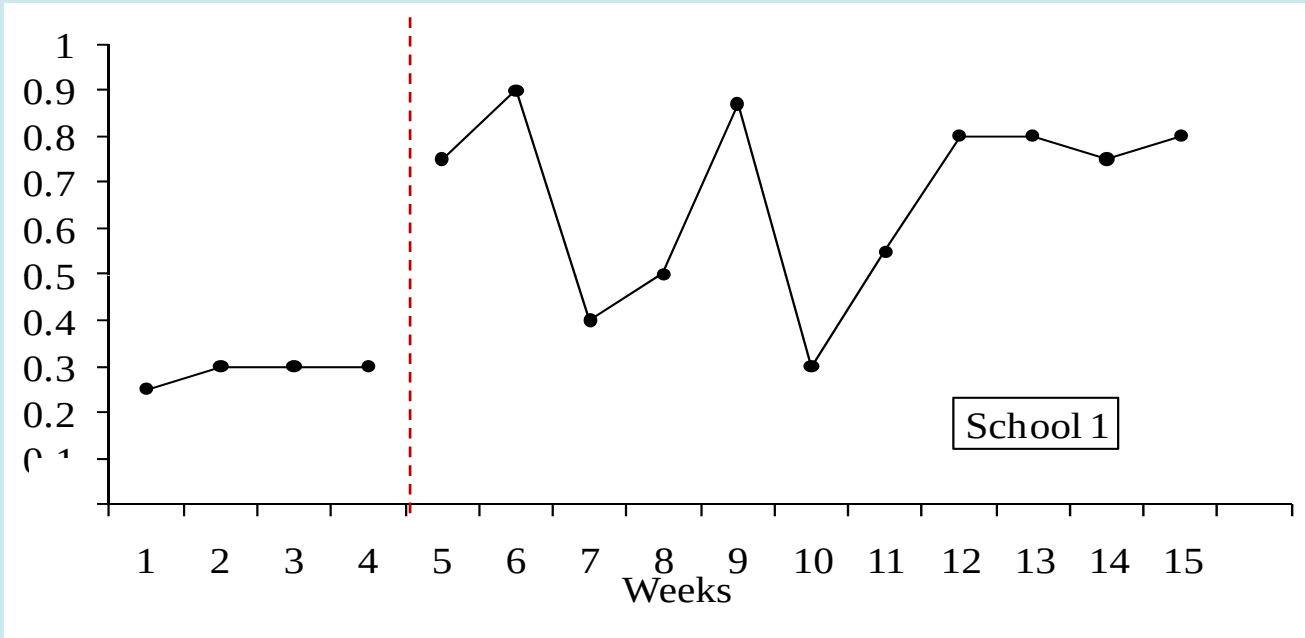
Implementation Integrity of…

- Problem-solving process
- PST process
- Individual Interventions
  - Observation
  - Permanent Product

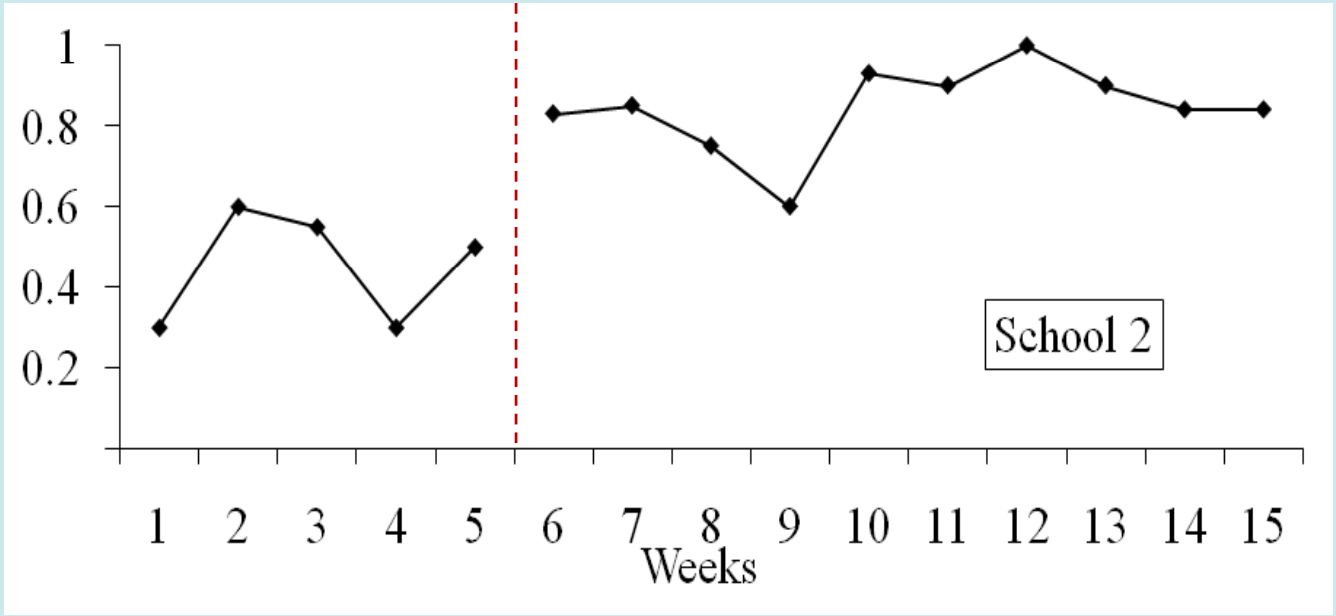
Item	Yes	No
1. Team meets on a consistent (e.g., weekly) basis.		
2. A "Request for Assistance Form" (RAF) is used to identify problem and provide data before the meeting.		
3. The RAF is brief, but provides adequate information about the problem.		
4. Documentation of consultant meeting with teacher prior to PST meeting.		
5. Baseline data are collected and presented.		
6. Data are objective and empirical.		
7. Selected interventions are research-based.		
8. Selected intervention is directly linked to assessment data.		
9. Start with interventions that have a high-probability of succes		
10. Consulting personnel assist with implementation of intervention.		
11. Team develops specific implementation plan with teacher.		
12. Parent information is discussed.		

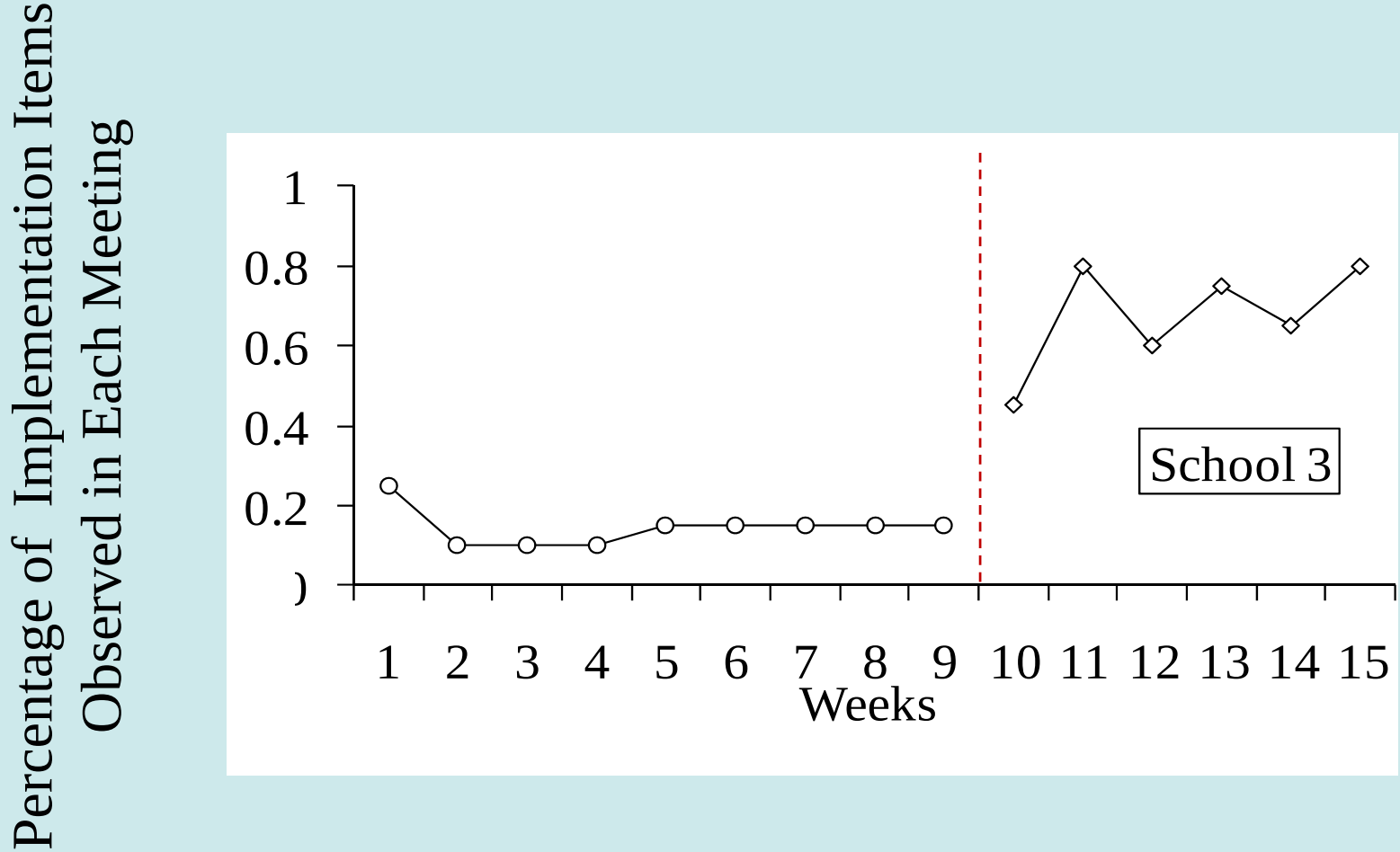
Item	Yes	No
13. Data collection plan is developed to monitor effectiveness and progress.		
14. Monitoring data are objective, empirical, and directly linked to the problem.		
15. A plan is developed to assess implementation integrity of the intervention.		
16. Follow-up consultation is scheduled between teacher and one PST member.		
17. Follow-up meeting is scheduled.		
18. A case documentation form is used to track the team's activities.		
19. The building principal or administrative designee is present at the meeting.		
20. PST members have designated roles (e.g., note taker, discussion facilitator).		

Performance Feedback



Percentage of Implementation Items Observed in Each Meeting




Percentage of Implementation Items Observed in Each Meeting
1
0.8
0.6
0.4
0.2
0
1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15
Weeks
School 3

Items from the Observation Checklist and Mean Percentage of Times they were Observed Before and After Performance Feedback

	School 1		School 2		School 3	
Item	**Baseline**	**PFB**	**Baseline**	**PFB**	**Baseline**	**PFB**
Team meets on a consistent (e.g., weekly) basis.	00%	00%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Request for Assistance Form (RAF) is used to identify problem and provide data before the meeting.	57%	100%	100%	93%	00%	100%
The RAF is brief, but provides adequate information about the problem.	57%	100%	100%	100%	00%	100%
Documentation of consultant meeting with teacher prior to PST meeting.	100%	67%	63%	93%	00%	57%
Baseline data are collected and presented.	57%	83%	25%	93%	00%	100%
Data are objective and empirical.	71%	75%	63%	73%	22%	100%
Selected interventions are research-based.	29%	73%	25%	82%	00%	57%
Selected intervention is directly linked to assessment data.	29%	82%	38%	100%	00%	71%
Start with interventions that have a high-probability of success.	29%	73%	13%	75%	00%	57%
Consulting personnel assist with implementation of intervention.	43%	75%	38%	82%	00%	43%
Team develops specific implementation plan with teacher.	29%	73%	13%	36%	00%	29%

Note. PFB = Performance Feedback

Items from the Observation Checklist and Mean Percentage of Times they were Observed Before and After Performance Feedback

	School 1		School 2		School 3	
Item	**Baseline**	**PFB**	**Baseline**	**PFB**	**Baseline**	**PFB**
Parent information is discussed.	86%	100%	100%	87%	67%	100%
Data collection plan is developed to monitor effectiveness and progress.	43%	55%	38%	18%	00%	43%
Monitoring data are objective, empirical, and directly linked to the problem.	43%	55%	38%	45%	11%	43%
A plan is developed to assess implementation integrity of the intervention.	00%	55%	00%	00%	00%	14%
Follow-up consultation is scheduled between teacher and one PST member.	67%	70%	50%	87%	00%	86%
Follow-up meeting is scheduled.	50%	80%	50%	83%	00%	100%
A case documentation form is used to track the team's activities.	100%	100%	100%	100%	00%	71%
The building principal or administrative designee is present at the meeting.	29%	58%	88%	20%	100%	100%
PST members have designated roles (e.g., note taker, discussion facilitator).	00%	17%	00%	100%	00%	100%

Note. PFB = Performance Feedback

Parental Involvement

- Communication with parents throughout the entire problem-solving process is vital
- Invite to meeting
- Interview before
- Follow-up after
- Request for traditional evaluation

Summary

- A PST aligns with the problem solving model, including problem identification and analysis.
- Collaboration and consulting are key pieces to a successful PST.
- PSTs must be implemented with integrity in order to observe positive outcomes for students.

Resources

Burns, M.K., Appleton, J.J., & Stehouwer, J.D. (2005). Meta-analytic review of responsiveness-to-intervention research: Examining field-based and research-implemented models. *Journal of Psychoeducational Assessment, 23(4), 381-394.*

Burns, M. K., & Symington, T. (2002). A meta-analysis of prereferral intervention teams: Systemic and student outcomes. *Journal of School Psychology*, *40*, 437–447.

Daly, E.J. & Martens, B.K. (1997). A model for conducting a functional analysis of academic performance problems. School Psychology Review, 26(4), 554.

Additional Training Modules:

Intervention Central

Now, see if you can answer the following questions!

Both PITs and PSTs engage in collaboration, focus on individual students, and develop interventions.

True

False

Which type of team engages in each step of the IDEAL model?

a. Pre-referral Intervention Teams (PIT)

b. Problem-solving Teams (PST)

As part of the first step of consultation, you should define the problem within:

a. 2 to 5 days

b. 5 to 10 days

c. 2 weeks

Data should be collected via each of the following methods, except:

a. Reviewing records

b. Interviewing teachers and parents

c. Observing in multiple classrooms

d. Test the student on relevant measures

e. Talking in the teachers' lounge.



The role of the problem solving facilitator includes all of the following except:

a. Starts brainstorming about the intervention.

b. Gets the team back on track.

c. Focus the conversation on what is relevant and can be altered.

d. Focus the conversation on the problem without identifying solutions.